

Peasant and Nation

The Making of Postcolonial Mexico and Peru

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1 Political History from Below

Hegemony, the State, and Nationalist Discourses

On a clear and frigid morning fifteen years ago, in the second-floor archive of the Prefectura of Junín, Nelson Manrique, Ludy Ugarte, and I uncovered the first in a group of striking documents. For the past several months we had been ordering the dusty and disorganized papers of the prefect's archive, located in the city of Huancayo in Peru's central sierra. As this series of letters and official reports emerged from the mass of paper, dirt, and animal excrement we worked with every day, we saw that they dealt with an ongoing peasant mobilization in the community of Comas both during and after the War of the Pacific (1879–1884). According to these documents, the residents of Comas had formed a guerrilla force to defend their region from protracted Chilean occupation. After the end of the war, they had expected to be rewarded for their service to the nation. Instead, they were accused of stealing cattle from neighboring haciendas and treated like common criminals. They consequently rebelled against the newly reconstituted central government, creating an "independent federation" that survived for nearly twenty years. Only in the first few years of the twentieth century did they finally surrender, victims of a bloody counterinsurgency campaign.¹

Six months after our discovery, at a conference in the city of Ayacucho, Nelson Manrique and I began to understand its potential explosiveness. Listening to a presentation by Heracio Bonilla in which he argued that Peru had lost the war with Chile precisely because the population had no interest in defending national territory and no notion of what that meant, we both had the same reaction. Incensed at Bonilla's lack of attention to and respect for existing forms of popular resistance and consciousness, we felt we had to use the materials discovered in the central highlands to challenge his conclusions. Manrique stood and summarized our findings in the central highlands archive. There began a debate that continued for many years, informing and shaping the work of the three historians involved in those initial confrontations.

The theoretical framework within which Bonilla placed his argument was, and among many scholars still is, the dominant vision of nationalism as an ideology created by the bourgeoisie, along with the internal market, in a society undergoing a successful transition to capitalism. In societies such as nineteenth-century Peru, where there was no consolidated bourgeoisie or internal market and certainly no successful transition to capitalism, there could be no developed nationalism. This was especially true among subordinate classes and ethnic groups, to whom nationalist ideology came only secondarily after having been elaborated by the bourgeoisie as one of its "historic tasks." Thus Bonilla explained Peru's easy defeat by Chile in the War of the Pacific: while Chilean soldiers were fighting for their country, which they understood in nationalist terms, Peruvians at best fought for a personalistic patron, and at worst allied themselves with the invaders against their class or ethnic enemies.²

For Manrique and myself, this perspective simply did not explain the documents we had been finding in the central sierra. The more we became involved in the data, the more supporting evidence we began to find, and the more we became convinced that the indigenous peasantry itself formed the backbone of the resistance to the Chileans in that region. Contrary to what Bonilla would have predicted, the landowners and merchants ultimately allied with the Chileans, wishing to end the invasion and the consequent raiding and destruction of their properties. So the subaltern classes of the region led the nationalist struggle, quite against the interests of the local dominant classes. But how to explain this seeming contradiction? Was it possible to theorize nationalism to take this eventuality into account?

We began, perhaps inevitably, by romanticizing the central sierra peasantry and its nationalism. In my earlier work I saw nationalist consciousness emerging out of the resistance itself, through specific confrontations with a foreign invader, and I narrated the development of this consciousness from a perspective sympathetic to the peasants themselves. Manrique proposed that the very intensity of events as experienced in the central sierra allowed for the rapid acceleration of historical time, permitting the peasants to formulate a nationalist ideology and consciousness that they would not have developed under "normal" circumstances. Neither of us was clear, however, on how broadly one could generalize from this case to understanding nationalism in the context of state consolidation. Unable to go beyond presenting the data and arguing for the reality of the nationalist feeling involved, we had used a case study to question a paradigm, but we could neither explode it nor theorize a new perspective.³

Two stumbling blocks stood in our path. The first was that a single example could not bear the weight of an entire new approach. If the case of Peru's central highlands was exceptional, it might prove the rule that peasants were generally incapable of formulating broader national projects. The second problem was that, even if the central sierra were not an exception, existing approaches to and definitions of nationalism were not adequate for explaining what we had found. Manrique and I began, quite independently, to explore comparative angles and to rethink our approaches to popular politics and nation-state formation.⁴

My comparative research carried me first into northern Peru and then to Morelos and Puebla in central Mexico. By the time the archival dust had cleared, I was convinced that the Peruvian central sierra was not a unique case. Of the four regions I had studied, three developed a form of peasant nationalism out of the national and international struggles affecting their countries in the second half of the nineteenth century. No longer was it possible, then, to reconstruct the more orthodox approaches to nationalism by pronouncing the Peruvian central sierra an exception. Instead, an entirely new formulation was necessary, one that accounted for the active participation and intellectual creativity of subaltern classes in processes of nation-state formation.

The challenge, in my view, was to conceptualize nationalism and nationalist consciousness as analytically separate from—though historically connected to—the politics of the triumphant nation-state. That such an analytical separation proved so difficult is a tribute to the massive power of European capitalism and colonialism. But it does not change the fact that, in much of the literature on nationalism, the nationalist story told by the winners of the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century scramble for world power has been served up as objective truth. In this version, nationalism was an integrated ideology whose proponents or believers put the interests of the nation—an already defined, integrated community with a territory, language, and accepted set of historical traditions—before the more divisive loyalties of region, class, family, or ethnic group.⁵ And this was the yardstick held up to (or straitjacket forced on) any social group that ostensibly might or might not “have” nationalism or “be” nationalist: could such a loyalty be demonstrated to exist?

I have become convinced that few nineteenth-century social groups, whether in Latin America or elsewhere, could have passed this particular test. As an *ex post facto* construction of a much more complex history, this version of nationalism was offered precisely by the political factions that won the battles to control the nation-state. As such, it does little to help us

understand the struggles themselves, since its very purpose was to enshroud and bury the various and multitudinous debates and confrontations that had gone on before. And this is indeed the second challenge that Nelson Manrique and I faced in our work on the central highlands: the need to reformulate our conceptions of nationalism so that we could understand the complex politics of rural nineteenth-century Latin America without subjecting political actors to ineffective or useless tests that obscured more than they explained.

My new formulation of nationalism, then, began from the realization that nationalism as such cannot be demonstrated to exist, precisely because there is no single "real" version. Instead, I began to see nationalism as a broad vision for organizing society, a project for collective identity based on the premise of citizenship—available to all, with individual membership beginning from the assumption of legal equality. Within such a broad vision there was much room for disagreement; thus, in any particular case, nationalism would become a series of competing discourses in constant formation and negotiation, bounded by particular regional histories of power relations. For Mexico and Peru, my entry was through the specific questions that emerged from comparative study, not only in the types of documents and events that needed analysis but also in the historiographical debates existing in each case. In both countries the form in which questions were asked about peasant participation depended on the very political histories of state formation I was investigating.

In Peru the lack of a successful national-bourgeois revolution was articulated to the perception that the Indian majority had been unable to comprehend, much less creatively engage, concepts of nation and nationalism. Some radical thinkers, influenced by *indigenista* currents in the 1920s, suggested that an Indian-based socialism could resuscitate indigenous collective traditions and connect them to European Marxism, thus solving Peru's national problem. Conservatives, often in tandem with a sector of *indigenista* thinkers and politicians, argued instead that the only solution was the triumph of European culture. The failure of the Peruvian nation could be traced back to the Conquest, they suggested, and to the legacy of Inca despotism and authoritarianism that made Indian society and culture impervious to individual creativity, innovation, and market forces.⁶

In Mexico the existence of a revolutionary liberal tradition framed the discussion. While campesinos or Indian peasants had clearly participated in the three great conflagrations of modern Mexican history—independence, the 1855 Liberal Revolution, and the 1910 Revolution—had they done so as more than cannon fodder? Could they actually build, or participate in, popu-

lar liberalism? Liberal historians and intellectuals associated with the official revolutionary party (Partido Revolucionario Institucional, or PRI) answered both questions with a resounding "yes." In fact, they argued that the aspirations of peasants for land and social justice had fueled all three revolutions and had been answered and realized by the postrevolutionary Mexican state. Starting in the 1970s, however, revisionist scholars in the post-Tlatelolco generation began to suggest a different reading of the same events, in which Indians and peasants were constantly repressed and expropriated by an ever more centralized state.⁷

What connected my four cases, in two such distinct national settings, was my common quest to excavate political history from below. Such a history, however, could no longer be a simple celebration of subaltern agency. While peasants and other rural folk actively struggled and thought in national terms, they never emerged as influential members of the political coalitions that took control of the state. Why did peasants and other subordinate groups participate so dramatically in the political and ideological formulation of national projects, consciously making alliances across classes, ethnic groups, even regions, yet at the same time never form part of the alliance in power? Answering this question forced me to rethink my whole approach to politics, including my understandings of class, gender, race, ethnicity, and the state. This book constitutes my reworking of what I have learned, with the purpose of theorizing a new approach that will, I hope, have implications beyond the cases for which it has been developed.

The common theoretical image throughout is that of decentering. To take seriously the intellectual and cultural history of indigenous peasants, we must decenter the concepts of intellectual and community. To understand the role of subaltern people in history, we must decenter our vision of the historical process. To comprehend political history from below, we must decenter our concepts of politics. To incorporate local complexity and contentiousness into our understanding of state formation, we must decenter our concept of the state. And to understand ideas of nation and nationalism from below, we must decenter theories of nationalism by deconstructing the twin myths of bourgeois and Western exceptionalism.

To decenter our analysis of nationalism, we might fruitfully begin with Benedict Anderson's image of the nation as an "imagined community."⁸ "Imagining" means to create by using one's mind; it involves cultural, political, and intellectual construction. At least theoretically, anyone with an imagination can do it. Nationalism is, in this sense, a form of discourse—defined as the combination of intellectual and political practices that makes sense of events, objects, and relationships.

My use of the term *discourse* shares more with post-Marxist attempts to reformulate the work of Antonio Gramsci than with a poststructural emphasis on language. A discourse is a political as well as an intellectual process, because human struggles over power and meaning are intimately interconnected. Even if meanings are multiple and relational, hence always changing, people struggle with uneven access to power and knowledge in order to construct and tell their stories. Thus, the contingency and creativity of human imagining is conditioned by preexisting inequalities as well as by previous patterns of discursive practice. In making sense of these complex patterns of openness and closure, of agency and domination, I have found the concept of hegemony especially useful.⁹

Originally conceptualized by Antonio Gramsci as rule through a combination of coercion and consent, *hegemony* has since been defined in a variety of ways. I have found it necessary to go beyond equating hegemony with a belief in, or incorporation of, the dominant ideology. Instead, I will define hegemony in two distinct, though sometimes related, ways. First, hegemony is a set of nested, continuous processes through which power and meaning are contested, legitimated, and redefined at all levels of society. According to this definition, hegemony is hegemonic process: it can and does exist everywhere at all times. Second, hegemony is an actual end point, the result of hegemonic processes. An always dynamic or precarious balance, a contract or agreement, is reached among contesting forces. Because hegemonic processes have contributed to the emergence of a common social and moral project that includes popular as well as elite notions of political culture, those in power are then able to rule through a combination of coercion and consent.¹⁰

Using the first definition of hegemony, it is possible to analyze politics at all levels as nested arenas of contestation, where hegemonic processes are at work. In families, communities, political organizations, regions, and state structures, power is always being contested, legitimated, and redefined. Some projects, stories, or interpretations are winning out over others; some factions are defeating others. The interaction among different levels, locations, or organizations in a given society—say, between families and communities, communities and political parties, or regions and a central state—redefines not only each one of these political arenas internally but also the balance of forces among them.

In this constant, complex interaction among spaces of conflict and alliance, there are moments of greater change or transformation. These moments can be explained by analyzing the historical articulation of different hegemonic processes into a broader coalition or political movement. And it

is here that the second definition of hegemony enters. The leaders of a particular movement or coalition achieve hegemony as an endpoint only when they effectively garner to themselves ongoing legitimacy and support. They are successful in doing so if they partially incorporate the political aspirations or discourses of the movement's supporters. Only then can they rule through a combination of coercion and consent and effectively bring about a "cultural revolution."¹¹

The first definition of hegemony, therefore, is always useful in the analysis of processes of political conflict and alliance. The second, however, becomes useful only when a coalition achieves broader influence. Thus, a hegemonic process becomes a hegemonic outcome only when leaders partially deliver on their promises and control the terms of political discourse through incorporation as well as repression. Yet any outcome is precarious and unstable, subject once again to challenge and contestation.

Confusing process with outcome is doubly dangerous. In cases where a hegemonic outcome has been achieved, the contributions and struggles of subaltern groups will be reorganized and redefined, obfuscated and partially buried. In cases where hegemonic process has resulted in repression and violence, subaltern discourses and actions will simply disappear from the official story. In all cases the dynamic contributions of subaltern groups to the history of politics will be submerged and rearranged.

It seems particularly useful to apply these concepts of discourse and hegemony to our analysis of nationalism. If nationalism, as a form of imagining community, is an open-ended discourse, then why, according to most theories, does the imagining occur first and foremost in Europe? If the hegemonic practices around nationalism can involve a broad variety of social actors in an expanded discursive field, then why is nationalist ideology associated preferentially with the bourgeoisie? Answering these questions involves undoing what I have come to see as a triple knot: the historical tying together of democracy, nationalism, and colonialism.

Between the seventeenth century and the French Revolution, a new discourse of liberty and equality began to emerge in the world. This discourse arose, according to both Marxist and non-Marxist scholars, from a series of revolutions: the creation of a market economy; the rise of nation-states; the development of technology; and the formation of a world system—economic and political—through exploration and colonialism. Yet for most the stage for the "democratic revolution" was Western Europe.¹²

To transform our perspective on this democratic revolution, I wish to start from precisely the opposite assumption: to understand the play's central plot we need to place on center stage what has been relegated to the

scenery and the wings. Recent work has made clear that a world system—with markets, technological and financial innovation, and widespread and sophisticated cultural experimentation—existed already in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, when Europe was still very much on the periphery. As relative newcomers to world commercial relations, Europeans competed fiercely in a system that was geographically and socially stacked against them. During the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries a series of historical events combined to give Europe—especially what Janet Abu-Lughod calls the “Atlantic rim” of Spain, Portugal, and Genoa—the edge over declining commercial powers in Africa, Asia, and the Middle East.¹³

Thus, the capitalist world system, central to the transformations that underwrote the democratic revolution, was itself the product of competition and restructuring within an already widespread system of cultural and economic exchange. The victory of Europe in this process was a contingent one, resting on the colonization of America and the emergence of the Atlantic trade system as dominant within the new world system. The concept of Western exceptionalism, resting partially on the idea that Europe built the first world system, must be seen as an official story, constructed by the people who won the commercial wars of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries.

Further, what happened in Western Europe between the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries can be fully understood only with reference to the rest of the world. World trade, exploration, and conquest helped to buttress and extend the free-market system by facilitating the accumulations necessary for capitalist transition. The development of colonial mining and plantation economies in the Americas contributed to further innovations in technology and the organization of the labor process. Competition among European powers for broader markets and colonies, increased warfare, and the need to manage colonial struggles of various kinds fostered the development of the state. The concept of freedom was partially recast in dialectic with the concepts and relationships of “New World” slavery. The idea of nation, as an “imagined community,” grew in relation to its opposite: colony.¹⁴

But that is not the way the story usually gets told. In the official story, markets, capitalism, democracy, nationalism, and all other inventions originated in Europe and thus legitimated and explained European hegemony in the world as a whole. A crucial piece in this transformation was orientalism, defined by Edward Said as the set of discursive practices that made non-Western peoples into simple and unchanging “others” and then academically defined their essence. According to Said, orientalism became a systematic school of thought during the second colonial expansion of the

nineteenth century, operating as the discursive mirror image of Western exceptionalism. Through the construction of colonized peoples as unchanging "others," Europeans also constructed discourses about themselves that privileged Europe as the original location of all innovation.¹⁵ The democratic revolution was thus constructed as a European creation, and the development of democratic nation-states as the "historic task" of capitalism and the bourgeoisie.

In the story I wish to tell, the democratic revolution is the very process of tying together the triple knot of democracy, nationalism, and colonialism. Within this narrative the contradictory universality of capitalist, nationalist, and democratic discourses—of the "new" ideas of equality, nationality, and free market that supposedly applied to all—makes a great deal more sense. From the very beginning, the historical combination of democracy and nationalism with colonialism created a basic contradiction within national-democratic discourse. On the one hand, the universal promise of the discourse identified the potential autonomy, dignity, and equality of all peoples, and people, in the world. In practice, on the other hand, entire groups of people were barred from access to citizenship and liberty according to Eurocentric, class-, and gender-exclusionary criteria.¹⁶

This contradiction between promise and practice became a central tension in the historically dynamic construction of national-democratic discourses and movements, providing the space for struggles over their practice and meaning. Throughout the world between the eighteenth and twentieth centuries, the discourse of universal promise inspired struggles to break open the notion of citizenship. My book is precisely about such a moment, when Mexican and Peruvian peasants and other rural folk took up the challenge of national-democratic discourse and attempted to create their own version of a more egalitarian practice.¹⁷

Struggles over citizenship and liberty, attempts to expand and make real the universal promises of nationalism and democracy, can be understood as hegemonic processes. When subalterns engaged in conflict over power and meaning, they helped define the contours of what was possible in the making of nation-states. This approach helps us understand the contributions of popular politics and popular culture to the broad metanarratives of political history. Yet at the same time we must be careful not to focus excessively on hegemonic process. For if we lose track of power relations and their condensation in state structures, we will be unable to transcend the uncritical celebration of popular resistance.

The state, in this context, can best be understood as a series of decentralized sites of struggle through which hegemony is both contested and repro-

duced. State institutions are locations or spaces where conflicts over power are constantly being resolved and hierarchically reordered. Since these conflicts are never equal for all groups, in the long run they tend to reorder, reproduce, and represent relations as inequality and domination. Yet at the same time, because conflict is at the very core of the state, subaltern struggles are woven throughout the fabric of state institutions.¹⁸

Subaltern struggles themselves are not unified, transparent representations of popular culture. People give meaning to their experiences through the social and historical construction of multiple, crosscutting identities and power relations. Class relations—differences in wealth, work experience, and location in systems of production—help define and limit the contours of community and consciousness. Women and men give social meaning to sexual difference through gender relations, both between and within groups. Differences in power between the generations crosscut and help organize gender hierarchy. Ethnicity is the social construction of differences in color, culture, language, and dress; and in the context of specific class and gender systems, people historically define ethnic boundaries and identities in a three-way struggle: within and between ethnicities, and between the state and ethnic groups.¹⁹

In societies and in states, class, gender, and ethnic hierarchies are equally important in structuring and reproducing systems of domination. State structures combine these enduring hierarchies and power differences, through daily conflict and contingency, to construct and reconstruct a "pact of domination." The state can and does take different roles vis-à-vis inter- or intragroup ethnic, class, and gender conflicts, depending on its own interests in social control, reproduction, and security. And this complexity of overlapping conflicts, identities, and hierarchies contributes to the reproduction of a pact of domination, conceptualized best as a network of interlocking forms of power.²⁰

Viewed from below, the historical construction of a pact of domination involves subalterns as conscious actors rather than simply as those acted upon. Such a perspective, however, works only if we also rethink our view of rural communities and of peasant intellectual history. Too often peasants and other rural folk have been seen as acting only on the urging of their stomachs. A political history from a subaltern perspective must also take seriously the intellectual history of peasant action. This means, on the one hand, breaking down the artificial division between analyst as intellectual and peasant as subject—understanding analysis as a dialogue among intellectuals. And it means, on the other hand, rethinking our concepts of the rural community so that it is no longer "a given society- or culture-outside-

of-history but . . . a political association formed through processes of political and cultural creation and imagination."²¹ Let us begin with an exploration of the concept of the rural community.

Many analysts of rural history and peasant politics have shared an undifferentiated view of the rural community. Identities were stable and given, and communities were endowed with a primordial unity and collective legitimacy that did not need to be explained. In this context, political action was simply the representation, in the political sphere, of this unproblematic collective identity. Once such an approach was found wanting, however, the tendency was to discard the concept of community politics altogether. Political action became the province of village elites, who did not represent the interests of their fellow villagers; community institutions were seen as disciplining individuals to obey the rules established by elites.²²

Neither approach to communal politics, or to counterhegemonic politics more broadly, is sufficient. While romantic notions of "the community" are not helpful in explaining the complexity and contradiction of rural conflict, it is still true that counterhegemonic collective identities do sometimes emerge from and contribute to social movements. While it is no longer possible to celebrate the unblemished heroism of popular struggle, smaller and even more impressive heroisms do stand out in the historical record as subaltern people have overcome divisions among themselves to take a collective political stand. Under such conditions the challenge for those of us wanting to understand popular political culture and action is to develop approaches that make visible both the hierarchy and the heroism, the solidarity and the surveillance. My starting point in meeting this challenge has been the concept of *communal hegemony*.

The idea of communal hegemony begins from the complexity and hierarchy of communal social and political relations. Even without identifiable social classes, the supposedly primordial unity of the community was based on kinship and its legitimacy on the figure of the father. Indeed, both gender and ethnic conflicts and hierarchies were worked out and reordered on the terrain of kinship and generational authority. Differences in wealth, too, were perceived within categories that emphasized lineage, ethnic identity, and generational status.²³

Rural communities were never undifferentiated wholes but historically dynamic entities whose identities and lines of unity or division were constantly being negotiated. The discourses of gender and ethnicity combined and wove together a series of struggles and transformations. While there were periods of greater change or continuity, the creation and transforma-

tion of the sociopolitical identities associated with the community were part of an open-ended process that never achieved closure.

If these apparently unchanging communal entities were historically contingent constructions, neither the colonial encounter nor the transition to capitalism transformed a *tabula rasa*. Instead, colonialism, nationalism, and capitalism added new possibilities to an already dynamic and complex discursive field. Our challenge is to understand how the multiple discourses of gender, race, ethnicity, and, increasingly, class interacted and were transformed and rebuilt historically, in the context of particular social formations, conditioned by the particular practices of the people involved.

The people who led the process of discursive transformation were local intellectuals. In the villages, local intellectuals were those who labored to reproduce and rearticulate local history and memory, to connect community discourses about local identity to constantly shifting patterns of power, solidarity, and consensus. Political officials, teachers, elders, and healers—these were the ones who “knew,” the ones to whom the community would turn in times of change or crisis, the ones who provided mediation with the outside. They supervised communal hegemonic processes, organizing and molding the different levels of communal dialogue and conflict into a credible consensus. As with any process of hegemony, of course, conflict and dialogue did not occur under conditions of equal access to power and knowledge; in fact, local intellectuals had greater access to both than did most villagers. But at the same time, community leaders and elites needed to demonstrate a commitment to the good of the collectivity and to formulate a discourse about local history, politics, and needs that would convince a broad sector of the village to give them their support. Local notables and village intellectuals spoke for the villages, then, not because they represented them or took advantage of them in some pure way but because a local political coalition had been built through processes of inclusion and exclusion.²⁴

The period of the national-democratic revolution provided an unusually challenging opportunity for local intellectuals. During a moment of deep rupture and transition between more hierarchically structured social, cultural, and political orders, struggles between old and new, high and low, powerful and powerless became particularly intense and fluid. Indeed, this historical opening greatly facilitated and made more flexible the interplay between power structures and human agency, between hegemony and counterhegemony, between the accumulated discursive practices of the past and the constant new possibilities afforded by shifting fields of discourse. In the context of a new world system, the construction of a universalistic

democratic ideal was imbued with deep contradictions in its exclusionary practice. New discursive elements were fixed and others set free. People throughout the world struggled, with changing degrees of consciousness and uneven effectiveness, to hegemonize diverse combinations of the discursive elements and practices available to them.²⁵

The tensions and contradictions in national-democratic discourse were worked out historically and politically in three broad stages. The first was the moment in which the possibility of a national-democratic project emerged for a particular society; Partha Chatterjee calls this the "moment of departure."²⁶ New conjunctures of struggle and rebellion opened the way for potentially new hegemonic coalitions. In such a political opening, different possible projects or discourses emerged to compete for influence in the emerging balance of power.

The process of competition, which often—but not necessarily—took the form of violent conflict, constituted the second period. Chatterjee calls this the "moment of manoeuvre," during which new elites emerged as dominant in a national alliance through the "mobilization of the popular elements in the cause of [a democratic] struggle and, at the same time, a distancing of those elements from the structure of the state." Harnessing popular energy and creativity was central to the success of this maneuver, because only by utilizing the strength and dynamism of popular politics and culture could something new be created. Once used, however, subaltern movements would be politically excluded from the coalition in power and partially marginalized from the official version constructed about the struggle that had just ended.²⁷

This repression, exclusion, and marginalization constituted the third period, which Chatterjee calls the "moment of arrival." At this point a national-democratic discourse deemphasized radical rupture. It became "a discourse of order, of the rational organization of power . . . not only conducted in a single, consistent, unambiguous voice, [but also] . . . glossing over all earlier contradictions, divergences and differences."²⁸ At this point, in fact, the earlier conflicts were constructed as a process of natural evolution, supervised by the dominant groups whose "historic task" it was to bring about national unity.

A satisfactory historical analysis of nationalist movements all over the world must therefore come to grips with how the struggle between a universal national-democratic promise and a Eurocentric, patriarchal, and exclusionary practice worked itself out in each particular case. If we apply this perspective to the original debate among Bonilla, Manrique, and me about Peruvian peasants and the War of the Pacific, it becomes clear that the search for evidence of a predefined nationalist ideology in the

behavior of different classes and social groups will always be fruitless. Instead, within an open discursive field and with a constant eye for the interaction of structures and human action, we need to ask the following questions: What mobilizing effect does the universal promise of a national-democratic project have on different subaltern groups within a particular society or social formation? When and how do the colonial, patriarchal, and hierarchical underpinnings of nationalist discourse end up justifying the repression of the more radical forms of the national-popular? Finally, how are "the marks of disjuncture . . . suppressed" to create a unitary, rational, and linear account of historical development? At every point in the analysis we also need to ask how structures, as the embedded results of previous human action and struggles over meaning, condition and limit the possible outcomes of new action; and how new actions, struggles, and alliances modify and condition the reproduction of structures.²⁹ This, in short, is the kind of historical "archaeology" to which all nationalist movements must be subjected; and this, with all inevitable contradictions and limitations, is what I propose to do for nineteenth-century Mexico and Peru.

In Latin America the "long nineteenth century" between 1780 and 1930 was the period of the "democratic revolution," during which Latin Americans experienced and struggled with the twin processes of transition to capitalism and nation-state creation. Two massive upheavals in the Andes and Saint Domingue, in the 1780s and 1790s respectively, initiated deep crises of hegemony in the mature colonial empires. Alliances of colonized peoples rose up to question the colonial order and actively imagine alternative utopias. This initial challenge continued through the upheavals associated with independence between 1810 and 1825. Autonomy gave way to generalized civil war through midcentury and renewed efforts at state consolidation and economic development between 1850 and 1900. The general strengthening of states and national economies between 1910 and 1940 brought the period of nation-state formation to an end; for better or worse, the contemporary Latin American countries existed in recognizable form.³⁰

Mexico and Peru started the "long nineteenth century" as privileged centers of Spanish colonial rule. They were home to the largest indigenous populations and the most enduring indigenous cultures in the Americas. By 1940, however, they inhabited diametrically opposed sides of the spectrum, at least in terms of the hegemonic construction of a nation-state.

In Mexico a popular revolution beginning in 1910 resulted in a stable one-party state, where the ruling revolutionary party had institutionalized

the incorporation of the popular sectors, carried out a massive agrarian reform, and set the basis for the participation of the state in the economy and in negotiations between capital and labor. That this political system was not a democracy would become increasingly clear in the 1960s and 1970s; but the struggles within and outside the Mexican state had, between 1910 and 1940, successfully created and reproduced a national-populist discourse around which to articulate a hegemonic political alliance.³¹

In Peru, by contrast, in 1940 the state was still precariously perched on a series of negotiated convergences between a coastal bourgeoisie and various highland regional elites. A variety of opportunities had presented themselves, between 1910 and 1940, for a new political alliance to hegemonize state power around a more national-populist, inclusive core. The two most notable of these occurred in the early 1920s with Augusto Leguía and the indigenista movement and again in the 1930s and early 1940s with the rise of populist and working-class parties. Yet these openings had generally ended in repression. With the exception of occasional attempts by presidential candidates to court the Lima working classes, no political alliance or effort to hegemonize a national-popular discourse had reached successfully into the diverse and rich popular traditions and practices of the country's subaltern classes. Thus, in Peru, despite elections that were contests between competing political parties, popular political cultures had less presence in the formal political arena than they did in Mexico.³²

A close analysis of the period between 1850 and 1910, during which the first serious efforts were made in both countries to construct nation-states around hegemonic national-democratic discourses, is absolutely central to understanding the divergent paths taken by the two countries in the twentieth century. Yet at the same time the two countries' colonial legacies, combined with different independence processes, conditioned what was possible between 1850 and 1910. Specifically for the late colonial transitions, we can contrast a colonial crisis in Mexico that led to an independence movement rooted in popular struggle with a Peruvian crisis that set off an early civil war in the 1780s, the repression of which doomed popular participation during independence itself.³³

A broad popular movement in central Mexico, with a strong base in the Bajío mining region and in the villages of the center-south, initiated and backed the push for independence. Even though this movement was heavily repressed, some negotiation occurred with its major surviving leaders after 1821. In the first decades after independence, moreover, an emerging federalist faction inherited a connection to this surviving popular movement, and local or regional mediators found a place within the federalist

democratic ideal was imbued with deep contradictions in its exclusionary practice. New discursive elements were fixed and others set free. People throughout the world struggled, with changing degrees of consciousness and uneven effectiveness, to hegemonize diverse combinations of the discursive elements and practices available to them.²⁵

The tensions and contradictions in national-democratic discourse were worked out historically and politically in three broad stages. The first was the moment in which the possibility of a national-democratic project emerged for a particular society; Partha Chatterjee calls this the "moment of departure."²⁶ New conjunctures of struggle and rebellion opened the way for potentially new hegemonic coalitions. In such a political opening, different possible projects or discourses emerged to compete for influence in the emerging balance of power.

The process of competition, which often—but not necessarily—took the form of violent conflict, constituted the second period. Chatterjee calls this the "moment of manoeuvre," during which new elites emerged as dominant in a national alliance through the "mobilization of the popular elements in the cause of [a democratic] struggle and, at the same time, a distancing of those elements from the structure of the state." Harnessing popular energy and creativity was central to the success of this maneuver, because only by utilizing the strength and dynamism of popular politics and culture could something new be created. Once used, however, subaltern movements would be politically excluded from the coalition in power and partially marginalized from the official version constructed about the struggle that had just ended.²⁷

This repression, exclusion, and marginalization constituted the third period, which Chatterjee calls the "moment of arrival." At this point a national-democratic discourse deemphasized radical rupture. It became "a discourse of order, of the rational organization of power . . . not only conducted in a single, consistent, unambiguous voice, [but also] . . . glossing over all earlier contradictions, divergences and differences."²⁸ At this point, in fact, the earlier conflicts were constructed as a process of natural evolution, supervised by the dominant groups whose "historic task" it was to bring about national unity.

A satisfactory historical analysis of nationalist movements all over the world must therefore come to grips with how the struggle between a universal national-democratic promise and a Eurocentric, patriarchal, and exclusionary practice worked itself out in each particular case. If we apply this perspective to the original debate among Bonilla, Manrique, and me about Peruvian peasants and the War of the Pacific, it becomes clear that the search for evidence of a predefined nationalist ideology in the

behavior of different classes and social groups will always be fruitless. Instead, within an open discursive field and with a constant eye for the interaction of structures and human action, we need to ask the following questions: What mobilizing effect does the universal promise of a national-democratic project have on different subaltern groups within a particular society or social formation? When and how do the colonial, patriarchal, and hierarchical underpinnings of nationalist discourse end up justifying the repression of the more radical forms of the national-popular? Finally, how are "the marks of disjuncture . . . suppressed" to create a unitary, rational, and linear account of historical development? At every point in the analysis we also need to ask how structures, as the embedded results of previous human action and struggles over meaning, condition and limit the possible outcomes of new action; and how new actions, struggles, and alliances modify and condition the reproduction of structures.²⁹ This, in short, is the kind of historical "archaeology" to which all nationalist movements must be subjected; and this, with all inevitable contradictions and limitations, is what I propose to do for nineteenth-century Mexico and Peru.

In Latin America the "long nineteenth century" between 1780 and 1930 was the period of the "democratic revolution," during which Latin Americans experienced and struggled with the twin processes of transition to capitalism and nation-state creation. Two massive upheavals in the Andes and Saint Domingue, in the 1780s and 1790s respectively, initiated deep crises of hegemony in the mature colonial empires. Alliances of colonized peoples rose up to question the colonial order and actively imagine alternative utopias. This initial challenge continued through the upheavals associated with independence between 1810 and 1825. Autonomy gave way to generalized civil war through midcentury and renewed efforts at state consolidation and economic development between 1850 and 1900. The general strengthening of states and national economies between 1910 and 1940 brought the period of nation-state formation to an end; for better or worse, the contemporary Latin American countries existed in recognizable form.³⁰

Mexico and Peru started the "long nineteenth century" as privileged centers of Spanish colonial rule. They were home to the largest indigenous populations and the most enduring indigenous cultures in the Americas. By 1940, however, they inhabited diametrically opposed sides of the spectrum, at least in terms of the hegemonic construction of a nation-state.

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the incorporation of the popular sectors, carried out a massive agrarian reform, and set the basis for the participation of the state in the economy and in negotiations between capital and labor. That this political system was not a democracy would become increasingly clear in the 1960s and 1970s; but the struggles within and outside the Mexican state had, between 1910 and 1940, successfully created and reproduced a national-populist discourse around which to articulate a hegemonic political alliance.³¹

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movement. This faction did gain national power briefly in the late 1820s, facilitating the development of an alternative political culture at the local and regional levels. But it was only after 1855, when the Liberal Revolution brought the federalists to power once again, that it was possible to give a more consistent place to local issues, movements, and intellectuals in national politics. Indeed, the struggles around the Liberal Revolution and the French Intervention provided important new alternatives for local intellectuals, both in their local communities and in larger regional or even national coalitions.³⁴

In Peru the great Andean civil war, under the leadership of Túpac Amaru, constituted an early and unsuccessful popular protonational movement. The intense repression that followed decimated the local indigenous intelligentsia and instilled deep caution among surviving village leaders and political factions. When independence occurred in Peru, it was essentially a top-down affair, orchestrated from outside by the armies of José de San Martín and Simón Bolívar. Guerrilla participation was the exception rather than the rule. In the postindependence period, struggles over state power were centered in Lima and surrounding coastal regions, deepening the rift between highlands and coast that had been a part of the colonial system of rule. The War of the Pacific dramatized the political fragmentation of Peruvian territory and the failure of national or regional leaders to connect to local intellectuals.³⁵

Within these distinct contexts Mexican and Peruvian politicians and intellectuals faced a common quandary during the nineteenth century. Would it be possible to construct a nation, a community whose members were legally equal citizens, out of a society based on colonial regional divisions and ethnic hierarchies? In both cases liberals and conservatives debated the legal status and potential citizenship rights of the indigenous population. If under colonialism Indians had enjoyed a separate and protected status, as second-class citizens of an "Indian Republic," what would be appropriate for them in a postcolonial society?³⁶

In both countries during much of the nineteenth century, despite a common belief among most elite politicians that Indians were backward, uneducated, and degenerate, indigenous peoples did have the formal right to vote. What suffrage meant in practice, however, varied greatly depending on local relations and coalitions. In some areas, as those opposed to universal manhood suffrage argued, Indian votes were bandied about as so much political currency by landowners or other regional power brokers. When village leaders, local intellectuals, and other mediators had greater success in constructing broadly popular or populist alliances, however, suffrage could become a more effective exercise of citizenship rights.

Under such conditions it is perhaps not surprising that liberalism, as a revolutionary ideology, gained more influence in Mexico. The 1855 Revolution built on the popular and federalist legacies of the 1810–1850 period and connected to surviving regional popular movements throughout the center-south. This broad articulation of the notions and practice of citizenship gave Mexican liberalism, itself an internally variable and contradictory discourse, a greater strength and potential for growth. In Peru, by contrast, the legacy of Túpac Amaru and of independence lived on in the fragmentation of political space and in the inability of local and village intellectuals to articulate broader coalitions. Suffrage, under these conditions, did not serve to broaden the exercise of citizenship rights but generally to reinforce the more powerful regional brokers in relation to the central state. Beyond the ideas and writings of a few educated individuals, then, liberalism as a revolutionary ideology would gain little influence in nineteenth-century Peru.

In Mexico and Peru after 1850, broadly similar national questions would thus be raised and answered in very different ways. These conflicts over nation-state formation form the main empirical focus of my book. In both countries international war interrupted internal processes of negotiation, mobilization, and conflict. In Mexico the Conservative party countered their defeat in the 1858–1861 civil war by inviting the French Intervention and the creation of a new monarchy with the Austrian archduke Maximilian as emperor. In Peru geopolitical and economic conflict over nitrate deposits resulted in the War of the Pacific and the military occupation of Peru by the Chilean army between 1881 and 1884. It was in these moments of national emergency, when international struggles intersected with internal processes of attempted unification, that the richest, most varied and open possibilities for maneuver and discursive practice occurred. And the actual unfolding of the conflicts, with their shifting discourses and alliances, also helped define the possibilities for success in the incorporation or neutralization of the more radical or popular alternatives.

In both countries the universal promise of a national-democratic project had intense mobilizing effects on rural subaltern classes, effects that were further deepened by the actual physical presence of a foreign army. The message was clear: it was necessary for all, regardless of class or ethnic background, to mobilize in defense of national territory. In so doing, people would become part of the nation-in-the-making and be granted the rewards of effective citizenship—participation, inclusion, and a portion of the spoils of victory. In all four regions that form the empirical base for my study—Cajamarca and Junín in Peru, Morelos and Puebla in Mexico—people responded to the call. In Junín, Morelos, and Puebla

they organized irregular military forces on a village and communal basis and waged guerrilla war on the invaders. Called *montoneras* in Peru and national guards in Mexico, these irregular forces formed a sociopolitical space connecting local communal hegemonic practice to broader state apparatuses, especially the regular army.³⁷ And it was in this intermediate space, composed of discourse, structure, and action, that rural subalterns in all three areas constructed alternative national-democratic projects. In Cajamarca, where the intermediate space constructed by the *montoneras* was inhabited by an alliance of landowners, peasants, and merchants, control was in the hands of the landowners and merchants, and no alternative national-democratic discourse emerged.

Within the *montoneras* and national guards, subalterns struggled to create their own national-democratic vision. They used the notions of reciprocity, communal responsibility and accountability, and solidarity present in communal political culture to reinforce the universal promise of national-democratic discourse. Yet communal consensus was itself precarious, achieved through hegemonic process and coalition among a series of factions organized by lineage, generation, ethnicity, gender, and class. Not surprisingly, the possible outcomes in each case were varied and complex, offering a constantly changing panorama for articulation with other discourses and struggles in the society as a whole.

As communal discursive practices connected to the universality of the national-democratic promise, stretching the very edges of national-democratic discourse as a whole, the exclusionary practices within the national-democratic project began to come to the fore. In both countries the deepening fissures within the national-democratic alliance were papered over until the retreat of foreign troops was complete; but then the cracks opened violently. In the resulting civil wars the repression of the independent *montoneras* and national guards became the first priority. Indeed, the distancing of the popular elements from the reconstituting Mexican and Peruvian states was achieved, in the immediate postwar years, through blood and fire. Yet even in repression the different legacies and processes in Peru and Mexico would continue to construct distinct systems of rule.

In Mexico popular movements continued to ally with oppositional coalitions—most notably those led by Porfirio Díaz—through the 1870s. Even in the increasing authoritarianism and repression of the later Porfiriato, local intellectuals would guard village documents and memories and facilitate the survival of popular political cultures through 1910. The crisis of elite rule and ensuing civil war made possible, between 1910 and 1920, the re-emergence of these broad popular movements. In the 1920s and 1930s the

postrevolutionary state became hegemonic through the incorporation of a part of the popular agenda constructed from the 1850s.³⁸

In Peru, by contrast, the Pierolista state of the 1890s repressed the popular project by recreating the colonial ethnic fragmentation of "divide and rule." For the first time since 1836 limitations on suffrage effectively barred indigenous peoples from voting. The maintenance of a system of representation by provinces, moreover, underwrote the preponderant influence of highland and rural elites within the central state. The Peruvian attempt to construct a national-democratic state was thus abandoned by 1900, with the re-creation of a system of ethnically and regionally fragmented dominance that rested on contingent alliances with distinct regional elites. The 1969 military revolution would be a final and tardy attempt to hegemonize a national-democratic discourse and rebuild the state. It, too, had failed by the mid-1970s.³⁹

I do not wish to fall into a common error among historians, which is to argue that the period I study is *the* crucial juncture in understanding the entire process of the national-democratic revolutions. A decade of heavy archival work and theoretical reading pushes me precisely in that direction. But even as I resist the pressure, I must still insist that the popular democratic discourses constructed during the mid-nineteenth century, partially or completely repressed as they were in the following years, today still form a part of embedded memory and practice within popular political cultures. Recovering these discourses involves digging them out from under the dominant discourses that suppressed them, whether through the neocolonial "divide and rule" as in Peru or the successful construction of a hegemonic state as in Mexico. In both cases this recovery allows us to imagine more clearly how subaltern peoples might, after conquering the space to do so, create their own alternative polities.

A close examination of these popular democratic discourses will also help us to understand the Janus-faced, internally contradictory traditions and practices they represent. As the result of complex internal processes of struggle along gender, ethnic, and class lines, popular political cultures are both democratic and authoritarian, hegemonic and counterhegemonic. A central concern of my book is the understanding of popular politics as coalition, as a combination of domination and resistance, and as a powerful force in political change more generally.

And so a quest that began fifteen years ago, in a dusty archive, ends and begins again in the attempt to decenter our analysis of political history, rural communities, and national-democratic revolutions. The final layer of decentering must be, for me, the application of the concept of dialogue to my own

relationship to the historical actors who inhabit my narrative. I recognize openly the many layers of the dialogue. As the one constructing the narrative, I have power over its form and over the images of the actors it contains. In a way I am tearing down official stories only to build up a new one. Yet my efforts will bear fruit only if I am willing to listen, to open my narrative to contending voices and interpretations, to struggle to avoid the role of the omniscient or positivistic narrator.⁴⁰

I take some comfort in Raymond Williams's statement that "a lived hegemony is always a process. It is not, except analytically, a system or structure." In this sense we all contribute to and are complicit with a process over which we cannot establish control. The struggle to identify the discourses, actions, and relationships I excavate will itself become part of a hegemonic process. In this way I too am a link in the ongoing chain of human agency and structure I am analyzing. For, to quote Williams once again, "it is significant that much of the most accessible and influential work of the counter-hegemony is historical: the recovery of discarded areas, or the redress of selective and reductive interpretations." But as Williams also points out, the recovery of submerged or discarded discourses and debates makes little difference "unless the lines to the present . . . are clearly and actively traced."⁴¹ This process of tracing connections—between myself and local intellectuals, between submerged and unsubmerged discourses, between what happened then and what happens now and in the future—places me squarely inside the struggles over power and meaning. I cannot stand outside or above them, and in any case I would not want to.